STRIFE & SERENITY

KA’SIPHO MEETS RILEY & XEPHYRAX

EXT. ZOTHAR — DAY

Ka'Sipho walks alone. A little way behind him, Riley and Xephyrax try to approach unnoticed.

Ka'Sipho turns. Riley immediately drops to the ground and lies still.

XEPHYRAX

What...
...in the world are you doing, Riley?

RILEY

Playing dead...?
In case he spotted us...??
LIKE YOU SUGGESTED...???

XEPHYRAX

Oh?
Why, isn't that funny. I don't recall such a thing.
Who knows? Perhaps if we stay perfectly still...

RILEY

You perfectly SUCK, you know that?

KA'SIPHO

Somehow I get the feeling that you two aren't ZARIMAR.

RILEY

And what makes you say that??

KA'SIPHO

Well...
Last I checked, Dragons don't make the cut.

XEPHYRAX

Ah, yes. The least discriminatory human...

Ka'Sipho and Xephyrax stare at one another. Riley starts to get up.

RILEY

Mmmmmkay, just gonna...

KA'SIPHO

...look, man that's not what I—

XEPHYRAX

I only jest.

KA'SIPHO

Oh, neat.

RILEY

And now it's YOUR turn to look, MAN...

XEPHYRAX

We are companions of Mara. We merely seek to help, not harm.

RILEY

Aww, I wanted to tell him that...

XEPHYRAX

Alas, the rule of snoozing and losing strikes again.

KA'SIPHO

Right, so you two thought the best way to show me you meant no harm...
...was to sneak up on me from behind.

XEPHYRAX

Companions, not competent planners.

RILEY

Yeah! What he said!
Anyway, you're Kah-See-Foe, right?

KA'SIPHO

It's one word, but sure.

RILEY

Just gettin' a feel for it!
Ka'Sipho! Nice to finally meet Mr. Keep-Moving-Forward himself!

At the nickname, Ka'Sipho stiffens.

RILEY

No need to get tense. Mara told us a lot about you on the missions we joined her on!
I'm Riley, and that's Xephyrax!

XEPHYRAX

Charmed, I'm sure.

KA'SIPHO

Zeh-Fur-Axe...

RILEY

All one word!

KA'SIPHO

I know that—!

RILEY

We're from different Sub-Verses, but it's thanks to her that we met!
We owe her a bunch! But... now we're worried about her a bunch more...

Riley's grin fades.

XEPHYRAX

Indeed. When we overheard that she had gone missing, we thought to seek her closest out. Likely being you.

RILEY

Yeah... with the number of ZARIMAR we saw looking for her, you'd think she's gone and MURDERED someone...

Ka'Sipho says nothing. Riley and Xephyrax both look at him.

RILEY

WH--!?!?

XEPHYRAX

WHY IS YOUR SILENCE SPEAKING VOLUMES?!

RILEY

WHAT HE SAID!!!

KA'SIPHO

I'm just as in the dark as you are.
Whatever happened, whatever the reason, I'll find out here.

RILEY

Sure... ah— we'll tag along, then...

Riley and Xephyrax fall into step with him.

REFLECTION

Riley's 'All one word!' is another callback. This time, to Ka'Sipho correcting the pronunciation of his name moments earlier. When he stumbles over Xephyrax's name, Riley gets to throw the line right back at him. It's a small joke, demonstrates Riley’s playful personality, and is a satisfying callback for the reader.